Among the captains I played against, I consider Nasser Hussain the best. He was an excellent strategist and even if some of his tactics occasionally bordered on the negative – using the left-arm spinner Ashley Giles to bowl to me outside my leg stump from over the wicket, for example – he was a very good thinker about the game and was proactive. Nasser would not place a fielder in a particular position *after* a shot was played. Rather, he had the ability to anticipate the shot and would place a fielder well in advance, making a real difference to his team.

Among the Australians, I rate Michael Clarke as the best captain I played against. While I was too young to judge Allan Border in 1992, the other Australian captains in Mark Taylor, Steve Waugh and Ricky Ponting benefited from having some of the greatest players of our generation in their teams. With so many match-winners, the role of the captain is automatically reduced. Clarke's case, however, was different. He had to rebuild the Australian team from scratch and to do so in such a short time speaks volumes for his ability as leader.

Graeme Smith of South Africa is yet another player I have great regard for as skipper. Taking over the reins of the side at the age of twenty-two in the most tumultuous of conditions, Smith did brilliantly to propel South Africa to the top of the world Test rankings.

Looking back at my own captaincy career, I feel I could have achieved better results during my first stint as captain had there been more cooperation. I never felt totally comfortable with the relationship with the selectors. This was reflected in the teams I was given, which were not always the ones I would have chosen. In my first stint as captain of India, it seemed that each series was a personal test and losing one series badly meant my position was immediately in question. Such pressure did not always send out the best signal and it was as if I was constantly being evaluated. Every captain sets out to win but it's not always possible to do so in international sport. The opposition were also playing to win and at times they simply played better cricket than we did. That was the case in Australia in December 1999.

There is no point lamenting what could have been. It was time to look beyond the captaincy and contribute to the team in the best way possible. I am glad I was able to do so for a good thirteen years after giving up the captaincy in February 2000.